My bathing machine: design studio

10 POINTS

A bathing machine was a little hut on wheels that carried a swimmer down the beach and into the sea. Here are real ones. Now design your own! It can be sensible or silly. Draw it big, on the beach below.



Ordinary bathing machines at Shanklin, 1889 · Henry Pauw van Wieldrecht (Rijksmuseum), 1889, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons



Queen Victoria's own, at Osborne · Steve Daniels, 2017, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons

SIDE VIEW: DRAW YOUR MACHINE HERE

sand

sea

- **Don't forget…**

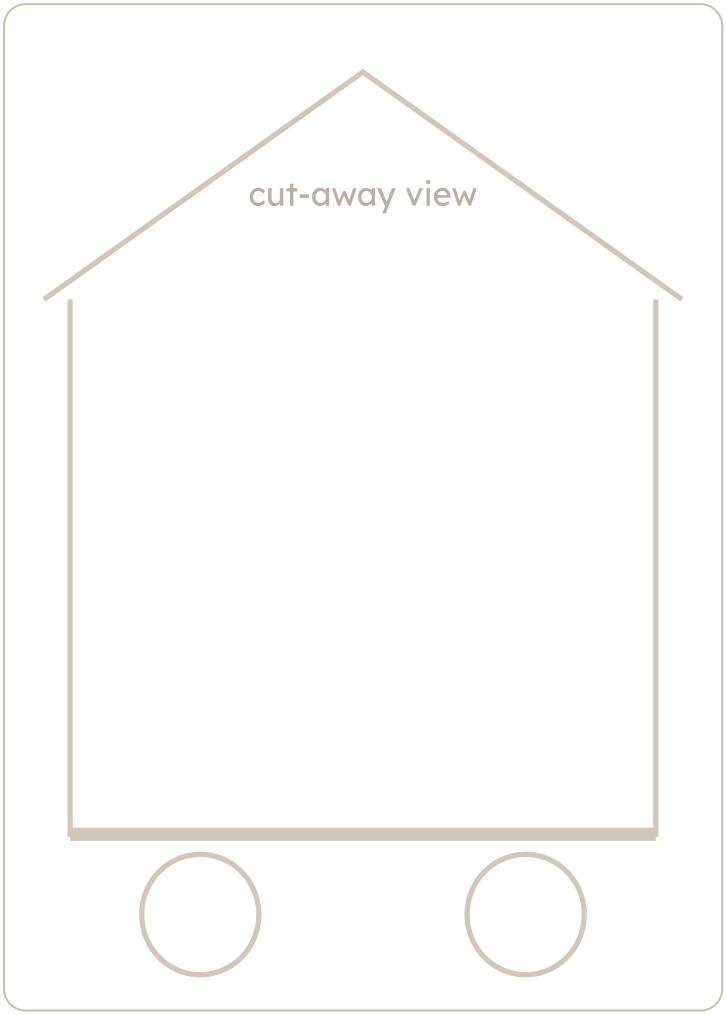
- [ ] big wheels
- [ ] a door at the sea end
- [ ] steps into the water
- [ ] a small window
- [ ] a roof
- [ ] a flag, name or number
- [ ] stripes or a pattern
- [ ] how it moves
- [ ] who is swimming today?

Name _____ Date _____

Inside my bathing machine

10 POINTS

Take the side off and look inside. What would a Victorian swimmer need? A seat, a towel rail, hooks for clothes, a mirror, a bucket… and what would you add? Draw it, then label it.



Inside there is…

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

4 _____

5 _____

6 _____

My machine is called

_____

It moves because…

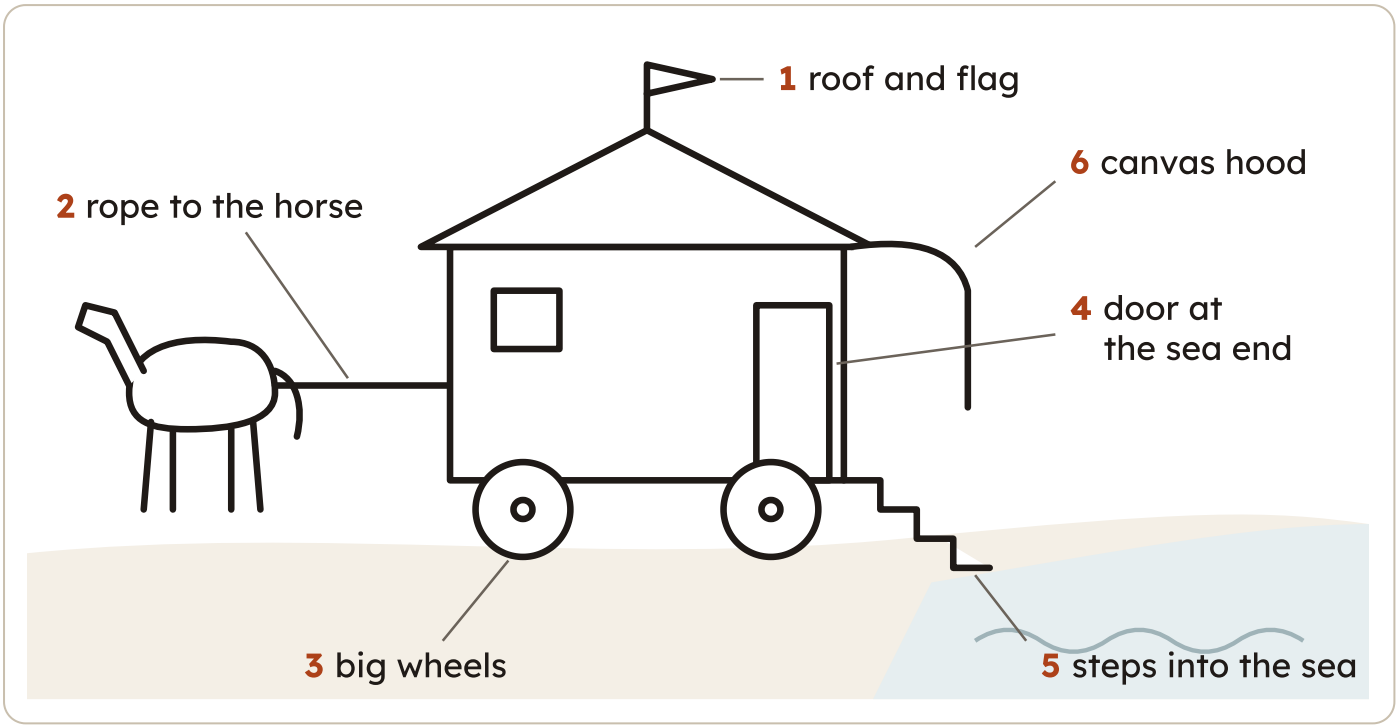
- ☐ a horse pulls it
- ☐ a steam engine
- ☐ sails and wind
- ☐ people push it
- ☐ rockets!
- ☐ my own idea

What if…

…it floated like a boat? …it had a slide straight into the sea? …it was for a dog, a queen, or a whole class? …it could go under the water? Draw your best "what if" on the back of this sheet.

How a real bathing machine worked

10 POINTS



1. You climb in at the beach end and shut the door.
2. Inside, you change into your bathing costume while the machine is pulled down the sand, usually by a horse.
3. In the water, the door at the sea end opens. You go down the steps into the sea, where nobody on the beach can see you.
4. A strong helper called a "dipper" is there to hold you and dip you under the waves.
5. Raise the little flag to tell the driver you are ready. Climb back in, dry off and get dressed while the machine is pulled back up the beach.
6. Some machines had a canvas hood over the sea door, so the bather was hidden completely.

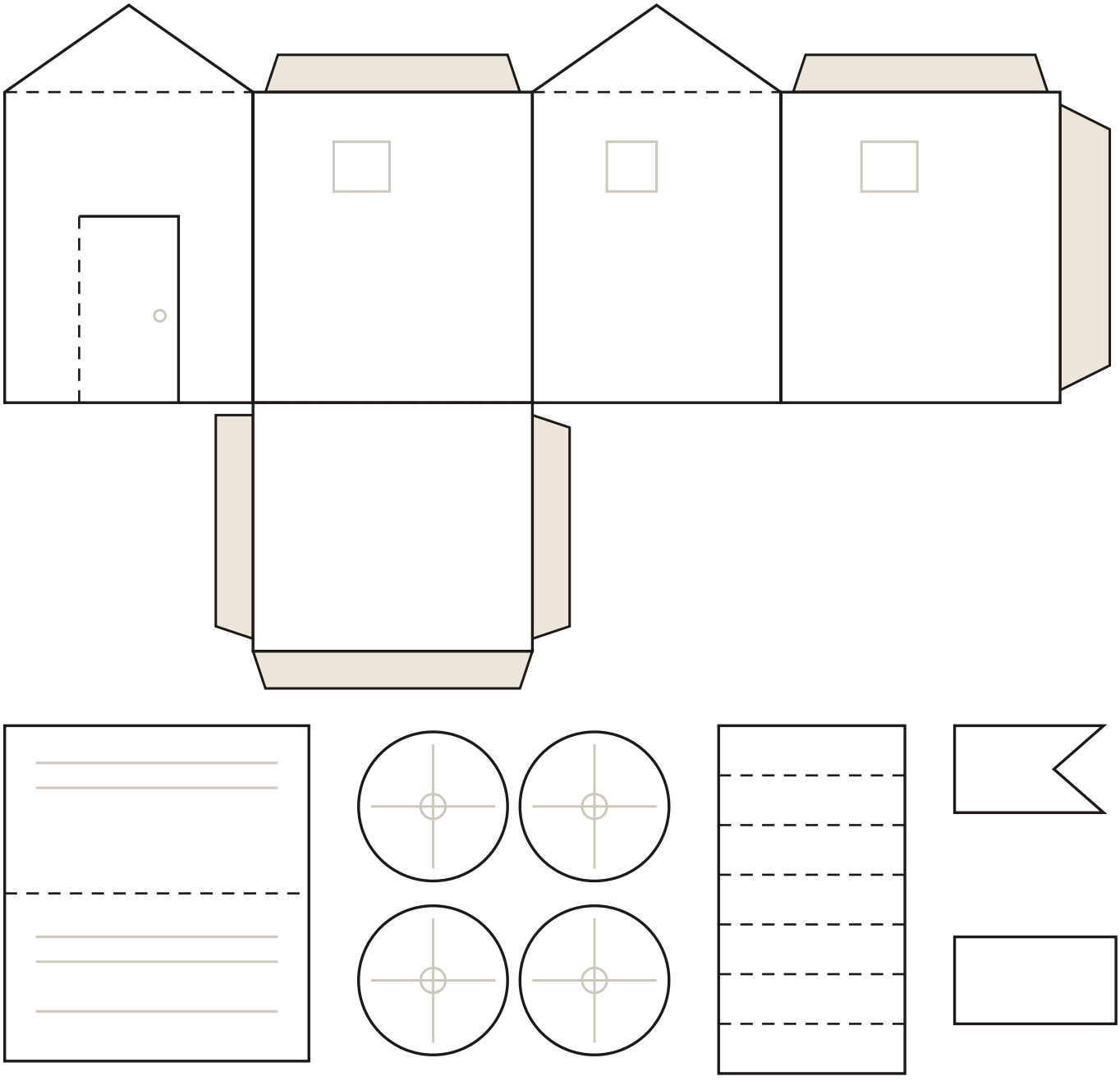
Did you know?

- A bathing machine was a beach hut on wheels. Queen Victoria's was about 12 feet long, the length of a small car.
- A horse pulled it into the sea. Then the driver unhitched the horse and went back up the beach to fetch the next machine.
- Benjamin Beale, a glove maker from Margate, added a canvas hood that pulled down over the sea door so nobody could see the bather at all.
- A little flag on the roof could be raised to tell the driver you were ready to come back up the beach.
- Queen Victoria's own machine at Osborne House had a changing room, a plumbed-in toilet and a curtained veranda.
- At Clacton in 1873 a bathing machine cost sixpence for half an hour: six old pennies for about one TV programme's worth of swimming.

Make a model bathing machine

10 POINTS

Colour it first, then cut on the solid lines and fold on the dashed lines. Print on card if you can. Ask a grown-up to help with the cutting.



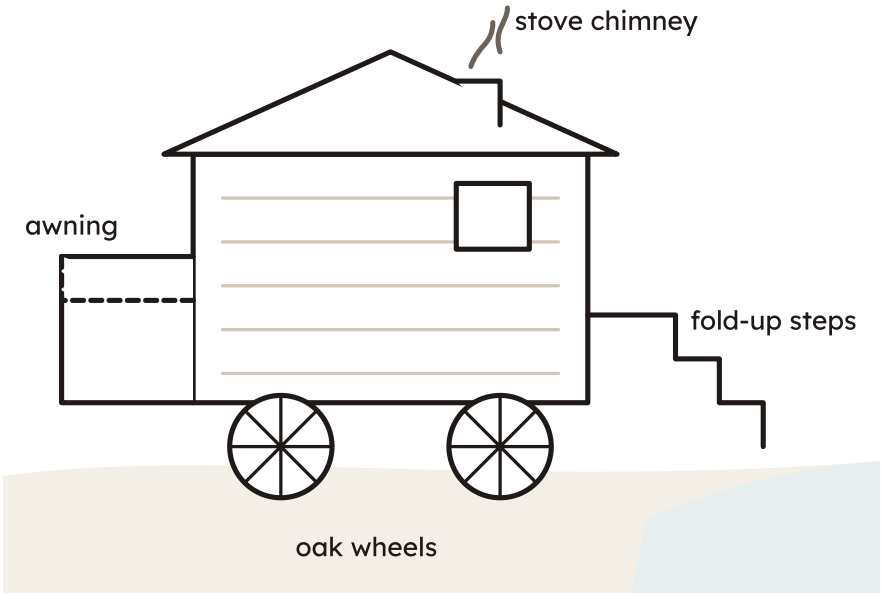
cut ---------- fold glue tab

1. Fold the four walls round into a box and glue the side tab.
2. Fold the floor in and glue its tabs inside.
3. Fold the roof in the middle and glue it on the top tabs.
4. Stick on the wheels, and the zigzag steps under the door.

A bathing machine today

10 POINTS

Bathing machines never quite went away. In 2019 a seaside skincare company called Haeckels put a brand-new one on the sands at Margate, with a sauna inside.



- A wooden hut on big oak wheels with a steel frame, built the way the Victorian ones were.
- Inside is a wood-burning sauna. You get hot, then sprint into the cold sea a few metres away.
- The steps fold up to become the door, and a waxed cloth awning rolls out over the front.
- Twenty people helped build it: an architect, joiners, a sauna maker and a wheelwright who makes wooden wheels.
- It was paid for by lots of people chipping in, and their names are engraved on the side. Anyone can use it for free.

What would you put in a modern one?

Source: Dezeen, "Haeckels' Victorian bathing machine warms up winter seaside dippers", 23 December 2019. Photos are on dezeen.com; the link is on the website.

Twenty ideas to make yours modern

10 POINTS

Borrow one, or mix three together. Tick the ones you like best.



Dazzle stripes
Black-and-white zigzags so it hides against the sea.



Periscope
Spy on the beach like a submarine.



Fold-out slide
Straight from the sea door into the waves.



Living roof
Grass, flowers and a bee hotel on top.



Whale shape
The door is its mouth and the tail is a diving board.



Glow lights
Colour-changing lights and glow stars on the ceiling.



Pedal power
Bicycle pedals inside: you pedal it into the sea.



Rain barrel and turbine
Rain for the shower, wind for the lights.



Double-decker
A bunk on top, with a diving board.



Secret drawer
For treasure and shells, and a bell to ring when you are ready.



Solar roof
Panels that warm the shower and light the inside.



Caterpillar tracks
Crawl over rocks and sand like a tank.



Sauna stove
A little chimney, like Margate's, to warm up after a dip.



Mirror walls
Shiny sides, so it vanishes into the sea and the sky.



Crab legs
It walks itself into the sea. No horse needed.



Sails
A mast and sails, so the wind pushes it along the sand.



Glass floor
A window in the floor to watch the fish and the crabs.



Fold-up
It folds flat like a tent and fits in the car boot.



Name, number, flag
A boat name, a number like Shanklin's, your own flag.



Victorian wallpaper
Inside, paper the walls with William Morris birds and flowers.

Draw your favourite idea

Name _____ Date _____ Sheet 6 of 6